

Sapiens

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8-slide visual summary

Core concepts • mental models • easy-to-remember diagrams •
practical takeaways

The Big Story

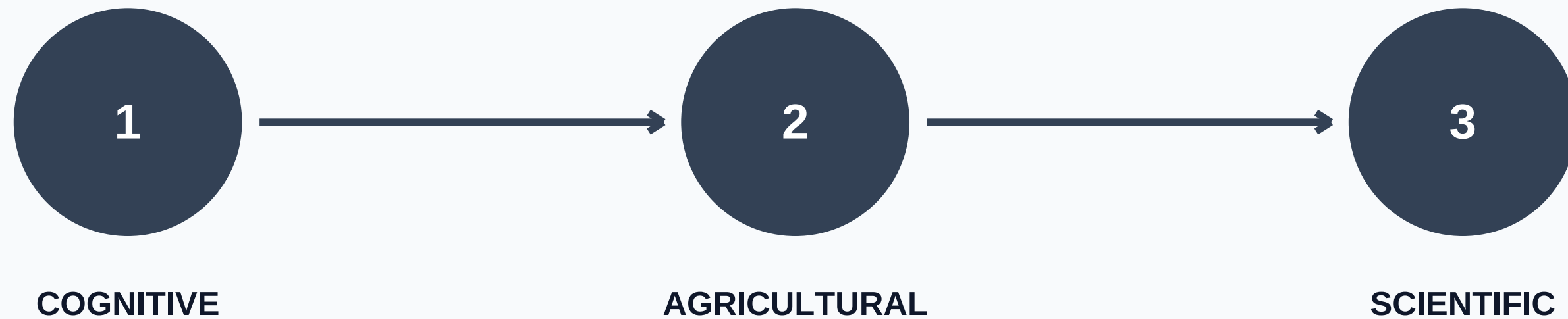
Humans became dominant through cooperation, stories and cumulative culture.



- Cognition enabled symbolic thinking.
- Culture preserved knowledge.
- Large-scale cooperation transformed the planet.

Three Revolutions

Cognitive → Agricultural → Scientific



- Cognitive: shared imagination.
- Agricultural: settled societies and surplus.
- Scientific: systematic discovery and acceleration.

Shared Fictions

Common beliefs let strangers coordinate at huge scale.



- Money.
- Law and institutions.
- Nations.
- Corporations.

Agriculture's Trade-Off

More food and population came with new costs.

GAINS

Food surplus Population Specialization

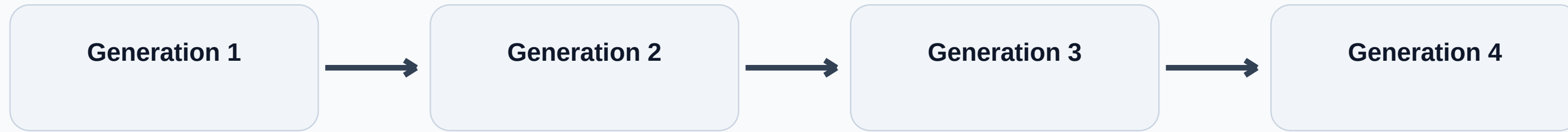
COSTS

Hierarchy Repetitive labor Dependence

- Specialization increased.
- States and hierarchy expanded.
- Repetitive labor and dependence also grew.

Culture Compounds

Each generation can build on previous knowledge.

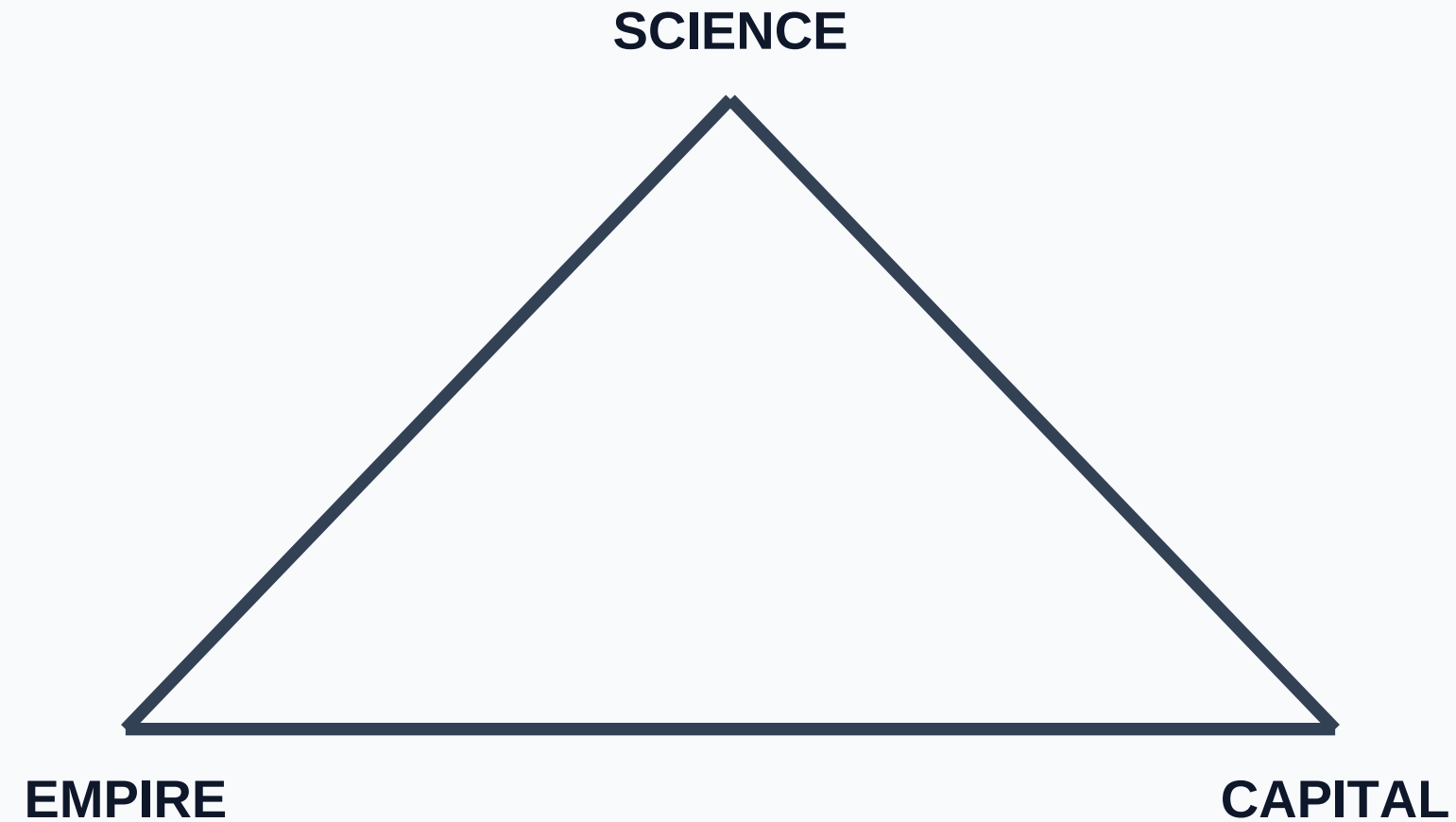


Each generation starts with the previous generation's knowledge.

- Language stores information.
- Institutions preserve rules.
- Technology preserves solutions.
- Knowledge accumulates.

Science + Empire + Capital

Modern expansion can be understood as a reinforcing triangle.



- Science expands knowledge.
- Political power expands systems.
- Capital funds exploration and growth.

Memory Map

Biology → Stories → Cooperation → Culture → Technology



- Ask what shared story coordinates a system.
- Ask what technology accelerates it.
- Ask who benefits and who pays the cost.